# Contend for the Faith

Blended chart deck for the Epistle of Jude

Leader resource · the six studies plus the original chart deck · NASB

The Gospel Vault

# Jude at a glance

*Six studies, and the bookends that frame them*

| Study 1 · vv.1–2 | Study 2 · vv.3–4 | Study 3 · vv.5–11 | Study 4 · vv.12–16 | Study 5 · vv.17–23 | Study 6 · vv.24–25 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Standing in the Storm**<br>Identity before battle: called, loved, kept | **The Battle Cry**<br>Contend for the once-for-all faith | **Three Warnings from History**<br>God judges contempt for His grace | **Portraits of Apostasy**<br>Recognize the counterfeit | **The Believer's Response**<br>Build, pray, keep, rescue | **The Doxology of Confidence**<br>He is able |

## Bookends — what Jude opens with, he closes with

### Kept
v.1 — kept for Jesus Christ
↕
v.24 — able to keep you

### The faith
v.3 — contend for the faith
↕
v.20 — build up on your most holy faith

### Mercy
v.2 — mercy be multiplied
↕
vv.21–23 — wait for mercy; show mercy

"The letter that opens with 'kept for Jesus Christ' will end with 'to Him who is able to keep you.' Everything in between is held inside that frame." — Study 1

# Jude thinks in threes

*Triads across the letter*

| Ref | One | Two | Three |
|---|---|---|---|
| **v.1** | called | beloved in God the Father | kept for Jesus Christ |
| **v.2** | mercy | peace | love |
| **vv.5–7** | Israel in the wilderness | angels who left their abode | Sodom and Gomorrah |
| **v.8** | defile the flesh | reject authority | revile angelic majesties |
| **v.11** | the way of Cain | the error of Balaam | the rebellion of Korah |
| **v.19** | cause divisions | worldly-minded | devoid of the Spirit |
| **vv.20–21** | building yourselves up | praying in the Holy Spirit | waiting for mercy (around "keep yourselves") |
| **vv.22–23** | have mercy on some who doubt | save others from the fire | on some have mercy with fear |
| **v.25** | before all time | now | forever |

# The "keep" frame

*The letter's frame word, traced through Jude*

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **v.1** | *"…called, beloved in God the Father, and kept for Jesus Christ"* | **τετηρημένοις**<br>tēreō · perf. pass. ptc. — kept, and remaining kept |
| **v.6** | *"angels who did not keep their own domain… He has kept in eternal bonds"* | **τηρήσαντας · τετήρηκεν**<br>Those who would not keep their place are kept in a place they did not choose |
| **v.13** | *"for whom the black darkness has been reserved forever"* | **τετήρηται**<br>"Reserved" is tēreō — darkness kept for them |
| **v.21** | *"keep yourselves in the love of God"* | **τηρήσατε**<br>aor. act. impv. — stay in the enjoyment of a love already given |
| **v.24** | *"Him who is able to keep you from stumbling"* | **φυλάξαι**<br>phylassō — to guard, a sentry's word (not tēreō) |

The commands sit inside the frame, not outside it. The believer's responsibility to live in God's love is never the foundation of his security; God's keeping is.

Study 1 of 6 · Jude 1–2

# Standing in the Storm: Grace, Mercy, and Peace

Before believers are called to contend for the faith, they are reminded of who they are: called, loved, and kept by God.

# Jude: from unbelief to bond-servant

*The writer behind the letter (v.1a)*

| Grew up with Jesus | Did not believe | Met the risen Lord | Among the believers | A bond-servant | Mercy for doubters |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| *"His brothers, James and Joseph and Simon and Judas"* **Matt 13:55** | *"Not even His brothers were believing in Him"* **John 7:5; Mark 3:21** | *The risen Christ "appeared to James"* **1 Cor 15:7** | *Mary and "His brothers" praying in the upper room* **Acts 1:14** | *"Jude, a bond-servant of Jesus Christ" — doulos* **Jude 1** | *"Have mercy on some, who are doubting"* **Jude 22** |

He could have written "brother of the Lord." He wrote "bond-servant of Jesus Christ" — and later calls Jesus "our only Master" (despotēs, v.4). He bows before he speaks.

# Called · beloved · kept

*Three things God has done (v.1b)*

### Called
κλητοῖς klētos · adj. (substantival)

- Placed last for emphasis — but first in experience
- God took the initiative; His call, answered by faith, is a settled fact (Rom 1:6–7)

### Beloved in God the Father
ἠγαπημένοις agapaō · perf. pass. ptc.

- Loved in the past and still loved — not a love on probation
- They live inside it; v.21 tells them to stay there
- Majority Text: "sanctified" — also perf. pass., same force

### Kept for Jesus Christ
τετηρημένοις tēreō · perf. pass. ptc.

- Kept, and remaining kept — God is the keeper
- The letter's frame word (vv.1, 6, 13, 21; cf. v.24)

All three hang on a single article — three views of the same people. Every word describes what God has done; none describes the readers' performance.

# Mercy, peace, and love — multiplied

*The greeting (v.2) and where each word returns*

## Mercy

**ἔλεος · eleos**

*LXX: chesed — steadfast covenant love*

Returns in vv.21–23: mercy awaited from Christ becomes mercy extended to the doubting

## Peace

**εἰρήνη · eirēnē**

*LXX: shalom — wholeness under God*

Peace in the storm, not from it — the intruders are still there in v.4

## Love

**ἀγάπη · agapē**

*Echoes "beloved" (v.1)*

Returns in the "love feasts" (v.12) and "keep yourselves in the love of God" (v.21)

"Be multiplied" — plēthyntheiē, aorist passive optative: a prayer for abundance, not rationing. God's supply grows as the pressure grows.

# Assurance: where does it rest?

*Reformed and Free Grace readings of "kept for Jesus Christ" (v.1)*

**Agreement** God preserves His people (Canons of Dort, Fifth Head; Murray, Redemption Accomplished and Applied).

## Reformed (counterpoint)

- God's preserving work necessarily produces the believer's perseverance in faith and holiness to the end
- Assurance comes, at least in part, from examining that perseverance (WCF 18.3; Schreiner and Caneday, The Race Set Before Us)

## Free Grace (series view)

- God's keeping is itself the guarantee — it does not depend on the believer's grip
- Assurance comes from looking at the promise and the One who keeps, not inward at our record (Dillow; Wilkin, Confident in Christ)
- Calvin: faith is "a firm and certain knowledge of God's benevolence" (Inst. 3.2.7)

The warnings of this letter are real — but they are not designed to make kept people wonder whether they are kept. (Study 1 §III.C)

Study 2 of 6 · Jude 3–4

# The Battle Cry: Contend Earnestly for the Faith

Because false teachers have turned God's grace into a license for sin, believers are called to contend earnestly — and graciously — for the once-for-all faith.

# The letter Jude did not write

*The change of plans (v.3)*

### The letter he planned
*"our common salvation"*

- koinos — shared, held in common (cf. "common faith," Titus 1:4)
- One salvation, held equally by every believer — not graded by performance
- A celebration

→

### The letter he wrote
*"contend earnestly for the faith"*

- "I felt the necessity" — anankēn eschon, the language of compulsion (cf. 1 Cor 9:16)
- Love for the church left him no choice
- A summons

v.3 gives the charge; v.4 gives the reason. Everything from v.5 to v.23 develops either the danger of v.4 or the response of v.3.

# The charge, phrase by phrase

*v.3b · "contend earnestly for the faith which was once for all handed down to the saints"*

| Phrase | Greek | What it means |
|---|---|---|
| **contend earnestly** | epagōnizesthai · pres. inf. (NT hapax) | From agōn, an athletic contest — an ongoing, strenuous struggle; in the manner of vv.9 and 20–23, not quarrelsomeness (2 Tim 2:24–25) |
| **the faith** | tē pistei · with the article | The content believed — the gospel and apostolic teaching. The struggle is for the message, not for the believer's standing |
| **once for all** | hapax | Decisive and unrepeatable (cf. Heb 9:26) — delivered complete |
| **handed down** | paradotheisē · aor. pass. ptc. | Technical term for authoritative tradition (1 Cor 15:3) — no later, "more enlightened" version |
| **to the saints** | tois hagiois | Entrusted to every believer, not a professional class |

# Five marks of the intruders

*v.4 · the reason for the charge*

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Crept in unnoticed** | **pareisedysan** | Slipped in by a side door — the danger came from within, quietly (cf. Gal 2:4) |
| 2 | **Long beforehand marked out for this condemnation** | **progegrammenoi** | "Written beforehand" — their condemnation already on the page in vv.5–16 |
| 3 | **Ungodly persons** | **asebeis** | Jude's signature word (vv.4, 15, 18) — a settled orientation, not struggling believers |
| 4 | **Turn the grace of our God into licentiousness** | **aselgeia** | Unrestrained sensuality — grace twisted into a license to sin |
| 5 | **Deny our only Master and Lord, Jesus Christ** | **arnoumenoi · despotēn** | An ongoing pattern; the despotēs Jude serves as doulos (v.1), they reject |

"They claimed the benefits of grace while refusing the Lord of grace." Jude does not call them believers: they are "devoid of the Spirit" (v.19).

# "Long beforehand marked out"

*Two readings of v.4*

### Reformed (counterpoint)

- A statement of eternal decree: these individuals were foreordained to condemnation (cf. 1 Pet 2:8)
- Draws on the classical doctrine of reprobation (Calvin; Westminster Confession ch.3)

### Free Grace / DTS (series view)

- progegrammenoi = "written beforehand" (cf. Rom 15:4)
- Jude immediately says "I desire to remind you" (v.5) and cites written examples and Enoch's prophecy (vv.5–16)
- Their condemnation was already on the page (Constable; Bible Knowledge Commentary; Wilkin, Is Calvinism Biblical?)

The focus stays where Jude puts it: on the certainty of God's judgment against those who corrupt His grace — not on a decree hidden in eternity.

# Grace, not license

*The charge critics bring against Free Grace — and the answer (v.4)*

**Agreement** Grace is never a license for sin — "Are we to continue in sin so that grace may increase? May it never be!" (Rom 6:1–2)

## Lordship Salvation (counterpoint)

- Free Grace teaching leads to the very error Jude condemns (MacArthur, The Gospel According to Jesus)
- Sproul: receiving Jesus as Savior but not as Lord is "antinomianism with a vengeance"
- Remedy: saving faith necessarily includes submission and persevering obedience

## Free Grace (series view)

- Keep the gospel offer free, as Jesus gave it (John 4:10; Rev 22:17)
- Press discipleship, holiness, and reward on those who believe — the Judgment Seat (2 Cor 5:10; 1 Cor 3:12–15) and discipline (Heb 12)
- Grace as freedom, not license (Swindoll; Hodges, Absolutely Free!, Grace in Eclipse)

The cure for counterfeit grace is not less grace — it is grace rightly understood, the grace that instructs us to deny ungodliness (Titus 2:11–12).

Study 3 of 6 · Jude 5–11

# Three Warnings from History: When Grace Is Misused

History shows that God faithfully judges those who despise His grace and authority; believers learn, like Michael, to leave judgment to the Lord.

# How vv.5–11 are built

*Example, application, contrast, conclusion, woe*

vv.5–7
**Three examples**
*Israel, angels, Sodom*

→

v.8
**Applied to "these"**
*defile, reject, revile*

→

v.9
**Michael in contrast**
*"The Lord rebuke you!"*

→

v.10
**The conclusion**
*destroyed by instinct*

→

v.11
**Woe and three men**
*Cain, Balaam, Korah*

Two triads — three collective examples (vv.5–7) and three individuals (v.11) — with the archangel standing between them as the model believers follow.

# Three examples of judgment

*vv.5–7 · each matched to the intruders of v.4*

| Example | Old Testament | What they did | Outcome | The intruders' mark |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Israel (v.5)** | Num 14:29–35; cf. 1 Cor 10; Heb 3–4 | Saved out of Egypt, then did not believe God at Kadesh | That generation died in the wilderness | Deny the Master (v.4) |
| **Angels (v.6)** | Gen 6:1–4, or the original fall; 2 Pet 2:4 | Did not keep their own domain; abandoned their proper abode | Kept in eternal bonds for the great day | Reject authority (v.8) |
| **Sodom and Gomorrah (v.7)** | Gen 19 | Gross immorality; went after strange flesh | Exhibited as an example of eternal fire | Grace into sensuality (v.4); defile the flesh (v.8) |

Unbelief, rebellion, immorality — exactly the marks of the intruders. Privilege did not exempt any of them from judgment.

# Israel in the wilderness (v.5)

*Does this verse threaten believers with the loss of eternal life?*

### Reformed (counterpoint)

- A central text for the view that people who once appeared saved can finally perish if they do not persevere
- NT warnings threaten eternal destruction and are the means God uses to keep the elect persevering (Schreiner and Caneday, The Race Set Before Us)

### Free Grace (series view)

- The wilderness judgment was physical death — they did not enter the land
- Moses, Aaron, and Miriam also died outside the land, and no one doubts they were believers
- Paul (1 Cor 10:1–11) and Hebrews (3–4) use this history to warn believers of discipline and lost reward (Dillow; Hodges, BKC "Hebrews")
- Jude applies it to intruders "devoid of the Spirit" (v.19)

The lesson: proximity to God's people protects no one. God judges unbelief, and He is not fooled.

# Michael and the intruders

*vv.8–10 · two ways of speaking about the spiritual realm*

## Michael the archangel (v.9)

- In a dispute with the devil himself over the body of Moses
- "Did not dare pronounce against him a railing judgment"
- Said, "The Lord rebuke you!" — the words of Zech 3:2
- He knew his place and referred judgment to God

## The intruders (vv.8, 10)

- "Dreamers" — claiming visions that freed them from moral boundaries (cf. Deut 13:1–5)
- Revile angelic majesties
- Revile what they do not understand
- Follow instinct like unreasoning animals — and are destroyed by it

**Where does the story come from?**

Not in the Old Testament (Deut 34:6). Clement of Alexandria and Origen placed it in the Assumption (Testament) of Moses, whose ending is lost. Quoting a source is not endorsing all of it — Paul quotes pagan poets (Acts 17:28; Titus 1:12). What Jude affirms, Scripture affirms.

# Woe to them: Cain, Balaam, Korah

*v.11 · walking → running → falling*

## Cain

*"gone the way of"*

**Old Testament**
Gen 4 · Heb 11:4 · 1 John 3:12

**The sin**
Came to God on his own terms, without faith; resentment, then violence

**The pattern**
Religion without faith, hostile to those who walk by faith

## Balaam

*"for pay… rushed headlong into the error of"*

**Old Testament**
Num 22–25; 31:16 · 2 Pet 2:15 · Rev 2:14

**The sin**
Prophet for hire; advised Balak to lead Israel into immorality and idolatry

**The pattern**
Profitable teaching that leads God's people into sin

## Korah

*"perished in the rebellion of"*

**Old Testament**
Num 16:3, 31–35

**The sin**
A Levite who claimed "all the congregation are holy" while seeking the priesthood

**The pattern**
Rejecting God-given authority (v.8) — an end as sure as his

"Woe" — a prophet's lament over certain judgment, not a curse spoken in anger. "Perished" is aorist: as certain as if it had already happened.

# Privilege did not protect them

*Six examples, one message (vv.5–11)*

**Israel**
had been rescued from Egypt

**The angels**
had been exalted

**Sodom**
had been warned by Lot

**Cain**
had been spoken to by God

**Balaam**
had received true prophecy

**Korah**
served at the tabernacle

God does not overlook contempt for His grace and His authority. For believers, this is not a threat to eternal life (vv.1, 24) but a call to sobriety — God disciplines His children (Heb 12:6), and all will give account (2 Cor 5:10).

Study 4 of 6 · Jude 12–16

# Portraits of Apostasy: What False Teachers Look Like

Jude exposes the false teachers through portraits from nature and the prophecy of Enoch, so that believers can recognize empty, self-serving religion and rest in the Lord's judgment.

# "These" — text, then application

*Jude cites a text or example, then points: "these" (οὗτοι)*

| Text | "These" |
|---|---|
| **Text · vv.5–7**<br>Israel, angels, Sodom | **"These" · v.8**<br>defile the flesh, reject authority, revile majesties |
| **Text · v.9**<br>Michael and the body of Moses | **"These" · v.10**<br>revile what they do not understand |
| **Text · v.11**<br>Cain, Balaam, Korah | **"These" · vv.12–13**<br>hidden reefs at your love feasts |
| **Text · vv.14–15**<br>Enoch prophesied "of these" (v.14) | **"These" · v.16**<br>grumblers, fault-finders, flatterers |
| **Text · vv.17–18**<br>The apostles' warning | **"These" · v.19**<br>divisive, worldly-minded, devoid of the Spirit |

Like an artist tapping the canvas — "look closely, this is what they are." Jude reasons from Scripture to identify the danger.

# Five portraits from creation

*vv.12–13 · sea, sky, earth, sea, heavens — promise without substance*

| Portrait | Realm | Scripture echo | What it exposes |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Hidden reefs in your love feasts (spilades) — "caring for themselves"* | Sea | Ezek 34 — shepherds who fed themselves | Calm surface, wreck beneath; feasting "without fear" |
| *Clouds without water, carried along by winds* | Sky | Prov 25:14 | Promised refreshment, delivered none; no stability (Eph 4:14) |
| *Autumn trees without fruit, doubly dead, uprooted* | Earth | Matt 7:16–20 | Harvest time and nothing on the branches — dead wood |
| *Wild waves of the sea, casting up their own shame like foam* | Sea | Isa 57:20 | Restless and noisy, producing only shame |
| *Wandering stars, for whom the black darkness has been reserved forever* | Heavens | Dan 12:3; 1 Enoch | Guides who lead people off course; darkness kept (tēreō) for them |

# The counterfeit and the real

*Study 4's conclusion: drink deeply from the real thing*

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Clouds without water** | → | **Christ, the living water**<br>John 4:10; 7:37–38 |
| **Autumn trees without fruit** | → | **Christ, the true Vine — whose life bears fruit in those who abide**<br>John 15:1–5 |
| **Wandering stars** | → | **Christ, the Bright Morning Star by which we steer**<br>Rev 22:16 |

"False teachers wander; we are kept."

# The fruit test

*Who is Jude's portrait meant to examine? (v.12)*

**Agreement** The men Jude describes are unsaved — Jude says so: "devoid of the Spirit" (v.19).

## Lordship (counterpoint)

- Fruitless trees are a general test of genuine salvation
- "You will know them by their fruits" (Matt 7:16) — the absence of fruit proves the absence of life (MacArthur, The Gospel According to Jesus)

## Free Grace (series view)

- In Matt 7:15–20 and Jude the test is applied to false teachers — including their teaching and its effects (Hodges; Wilkin)
- Jude never tells readers to inspect their own fruit; he tells them they are kept (v.1)
- Believers can be carnal for a time (1 Cor 3:1–3; John 15:2; 2 Pet 1:8–9) — the remedy is abiding, confession, and growth

Use Jude's portraits to recognize false teachers; rest your own assurance on God's promise.

# Enoch's prophecy

*vv.14–15 · the seventh from Adam*

## Two "sevenths" from Adam

**Line of Seth · 7th: Enoch**
"Walked with God; and he was not, for God took him" (Gen 5:24; Heb 11:5)

**Line of Cain · 7th: Lamech**
Boasted of violence (Gen 4:19–24)

## "Ungodly" four times in v.15

**asebeis · asebeias · ēsebēsan · asebeis**

*"to convict all the ungodly of all their ungodly deeds which they have done in an ungodly way, and of all the harsh things which ungodly sinners have spoken against Him"*

- "The Lord came" — a prophetic past: the future event is so certain it is described as done
- "His holy ones" — angels and the saints who return with Christ (Deut 33:2; Zech 14:5; Rev 19:14); in this series' premillennial framework, His return at the end of the Tribulation
- The words closely match 1 Enoch 1:9. Jude affirms this prophecy is true; that does not make 1 Enoch Scripture

# The plain portrait

*v.16 · each trait echoes something earlier in the letter*

| Trait | Greek | Meaning | Echo in Jude |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Grumblers** | gongystai | The low, complaining murmur | Israel in the wilderness (v.5; Num 14:27) |
| **Finding fault** | mempsimoiroi | "Blaming one's lot" — never content with God's gifts | The same wilderness generation |
| **Following after their own lusts** | — | Desire as their compass | Licentiousness (v.4); instinct (v.10) |
| **Speak arrogantly** | "swelling words" | Arrogant toward God and His authority | Revile majesties (v.8) |
| **Flattering people for advantage** | thaumazontes prosōpa | "Admiring faces" — favoritism (cf. James 2:1–9) | Balaam's profit motive (v.11) |

Real shepherds speak the truth in love to everyone alike (Eph 4:15). False shepherds tell people what they want to hear, and choose their audience by what they can get from it.

Study 5 of 6 · Jude 17–23

# The Believer's Response: Build, Pray, Keep, Rescue

Believers are called to remember the apostles' warnings, to keep themselves in the enjoyment of God's love, and to reach out in discerning mercy.

# "These" and "But you, beloved"

*vv.17–21 · two kinds of people*

| "These" · vv.8, 10, 12, 14, 16, 19 | "But you, beloved" · vv.17, 20 |
|---|---|
| Cause divisions (apodiorizontes) — the spiritual elite | Build yourselves up — together (the "yourselves" is plural) |
| Worldly-minded (psychikoi) — merely natural | On your most holy faith — the faith of v.3 |
| Devoid of the Spirit (pneuma mē echontes) | Praying in the Holy Spirit |
| Following after their own ungodly lusts (v.18) | Keep yourselves in the love of God |
| Mockers in the last time (v.18) | Waiting anxiously for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ |

"Devoid of the Spirit" is the key to the whole letter: the warnings are aimed at people who never possessed eternal life — not at believers who lost it.

# Remember · keep · reach out

*Jude's prescription — and his answer to "contend for the faith" (v.3)*

## Remember
vv.17–19

- "Remember" — aorist imperative
- The apostles saw this coming (Acts 20:29; 1 Tim 4:1; 2 Tim 3:1; 2 Pet 3:3)
- False teachers are a sign the apostles' words are being fulfilled — not that the gospel is failing

## Keep yourselves
vv.20–21

- Building on your most holy faith
- Praying in the Holy Spirit
- Keeping yourselves in the love of God
- Waiting for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ

## Reach out
vv.22–23

- Mercy to the doubting
- Snatching others from the fire
- Mercy with fear to the entangled

Contending is not primarily debating or denouncing. It is remembering, building, praying, keeping, looking for Christ — and rescuing.

# One command, three participles

*vv.20–21 · with a Trinitarian shape*

**Building yourselves up**
**epoikodomountes**
On your most holy faith — the faith of v.3. False teachers erode; believers build, together.

**Praying in the Holy Spirit**
Prompted, guided, empowered by the Spirit every believer has (Rom 8:26–27; Eph 6:18).
**The Spirit**

*Spirit · Father · Son — "praying in the Holy Spirit… the love of God… the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ"*

**Keep yourselves in the love of God**
tērēsate · aor. act. impv. — the main command

**The love of God**
God's love for believers — the love in which they are "beloved" (v.1).
**The Father**

**Waiting anxiously for mercy**
**prosdechomenoi**
Eager expectation of the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ to eternal life (Titus 2:13).
**The Son**

# "Keep yourselves in the love of God"

*Two readings of v.21*

## Reformed (counterpoint)

- Commands like this are conditions believers must meet to obtain eternal life at the end
- God ensures the elect will meet them — keeping oneself in God's love is, in part, keeping oneself saved (Schreiner and Caneday, The Race Set Before Us)

## Free Grace (series view)

- "The love of God" is God's love for believers (v.1) — they are already in it
- The command is to remain in the conscious enjoyment of it: "abide in My love" (John 15:9–10)
- Like a child in a loving home: membership settled by birth, but able to wander from the warmth (Hodges; Dillow)

Believers do not keep themselves in God's love to stay saved; they keep themselves in it because they are saved and want to live in the joy of it.

# Three kinds of mercy

*vv.22–23 · contending reaches outward*

### Have mercy on the doubting
diakrinomenous

- Wavering, torn between two positions (cf. James 1:6)
- Not dismissed or shamed — shown patience and help
- Jude once doubted his own brother (John 7:5)

### Save others, snatching them from the fire
harpazontes

- "A brand plucked from the fire" (Amos 4:11; Zech 3:2)
- Unbelievers near "eternal fire" (v.7) — bring them the gospel
- Or deceived believers headed for sin's ruin (cf. James 5:20)

### Have mercy with fear
espilōmenon

- Those deeply entangled in the intruders' immorality
- "Hating even the garment polluted by the flesh" (cf. Zech 3:3–4)
- Love the sinner, refuse the contamination (Gal 6:1)

Mercy does not mean naïveté: we reach into the mud to rescue someone without wallowing in it ourselves. (Manuscripts differ between two and three groups; the NASB follows three.)

Study 6 of 6 · Jude 24–25

# The Doxology of Confidence: He Is Able

The letter that called believers to contend ends by lifting their eyes to God, who is able to guard them and present them blameless with great joy.

# Him who is able

*v.24 · what God is able to do*

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Him who is able** | **tō dynamenō** | He leads with God's ability (Rom 16:25; Eph 3:20; Heb 7:25; 2 Tim 1:12) |
| **to keep you from stumbling** | **phylassō · aptaistous** | A sentry's word; "unstumbling" — sure-footed on a rocky path |
| **and to make you stand** | **stēsai** | Not admitted by a side door — set in place |
| **in the presence of His glory** | **katenōpion** | Face to face before the radiant majesty of God (cf. Isa 6:5) |
| **blameless** | **amōmous** | A sacrificial word — without defect (Heb 9:14; 1 Pet 1:19; Col 1:22) |
| **with great joy** | **en agalliasei** | Exultant gladness — ours and His (Heb 12:2; Zeph 3:17) |

After twenty-three verses of warnings, Jude's answer to "Will I be led astray?" is not "Try harder." It is "God is able to guard you."

# Stained or blameless

*The contrast Jude draws with one word family*

| The intruders | The believers |
| --- | --- |
| **v.12** "hidden reefs" — spilades (or "stains") | **v.24** "blameless" — amōmous, without blemish |
| **v.23** "the garment polluted" — espilōmenon, stained and remaining stained | **How?** Christ's righteousness, credited the moment one believes (Rom 4:5; 2 Cor 5:21; Col 1:22) |

Believers will appear at the Judgment Seat of Christ, where works are evaluated and rewards given or lost (2 Cor 5:10; 1 Cor 3:12–15). That evaluation concerns reward, not acceptance. Every believer will stand blameless in Christ.

# What belongs to God

*v.25 · four ascriptions answer the intruders' challenge*

| Ascription | Greek | Meaning | What the intruders challenged |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Glory** | doxa | The radiance of His character, the weight of His worth | — |
| **Majesty** | megalōsynē | Transcendent greatness — "the Majesty on high" (Heb 1:3; 8:1) | — |
| **Dominion** | kratos | Sovereign might, the power that prevails | They acted as if they could live outside God's rule |
| **Authority** | exousia | His rightful claim to rule | They "reject authority" (v.8) and deny "our only Master" (v.4) |

**before all time** | **now** | **forever**

*"The false teachers had their moment. God has eternity." — Study 6*

# What God's power guarantees

*Reformed and Free Grace readings of v.24*

**Agreement** The believer's security is grounded in the power of God, not human strength (Murray; Canons of Dort; Schreiner).

## Reformed (counterpoint)

- God's keeping power infallibly ensures that every true believer perseveres in faith and holiness to the end
- Perseverance therefore becomes the evidence of genuine faith

## Free Grace (series view)

- The guarantee rests in God's promise and Christ's finished work, not the believer's performance
- A believer's walk may falter; his eternal life does not (John 10:28–29)
- (Wilkin, Confident in Christ; Dillow, The Reign of the Servant Kings)

God's ability to guard us from stumbling is a resource we lean on for our walk; His ability to present us blameless is a certainty we rest on for our destiny.

# Jude and 2 Peter side by side

*Shared themes and order*

| Shared theme | Jude | 2 Peter |
|---|---|---|
| Intruders who deny the Master | v.4 | 2:1–3 |
| Angels held for judgment | v.6 | 2:4 |
| Sodom and Gomorrah | v.7 | 2:6 |
| Despise authority, revile majesties | v.8 | 2:10 |
| Angels refrain from reviling judgment | v.9 | 2:11 |
| Like unreasoning animals | v.10 | 2:12 |
| The error of Balaam | v.11 | 2:15 |
| Feasting with you; waterless clouds | v.12 | 2:13, 17 |
| Black darkness reserved | v.13 | 2:17 |
| Arrogant words | v.16 | 2:18 |
| Mockers in the last time | vv.17–18 | 3:2–3 |

# Where Jude and 2 Peter differ

*Same danger, different emphasis*

| Point | Jude | 2 Peter |
|---|---|---|
| **Timing** | The intruders have already crept in (v.4) | "There will also be false teachers" (2:1) |
| **Examples** | Judgment only — Israel, angels, Sodom; Cain, Balaam, Korah | Judgment and rescue — Noah in the flood, Lot from Sodom (2:5–9) |
| **Other sources** | Michael and Moses' body (v.9); Enoch's prophecy (vv.14–15) | No extra-biblical citations; the angel point is general (2:11) |
| **The call** | Contend; keep yourselves; rescue others (vv.3, 20–23) | Grow in grace and knowledge (3:18) |
| **Closing** | To Him who is able to keep you (vv.24–25) | To Him be the glory, now and to the day of eternity (3:18) |

# From "kept" to "able to keep"

"To those who are the called, beloved in God the Father, and kept for Jesus Christ" — Jude 1

"Now to Him who is able to keep you from stumbling" — Jude 24

*Not with our effort, but with His ability; not with our glory, but with His. Amen.*